THE OYSTER LIFECYCLE

Oysters go through four main stages as they grow. Each stage looks and behaves differently, from a tiny organism drifting through the water to an adult oyster attached to a hard surface.

EGG

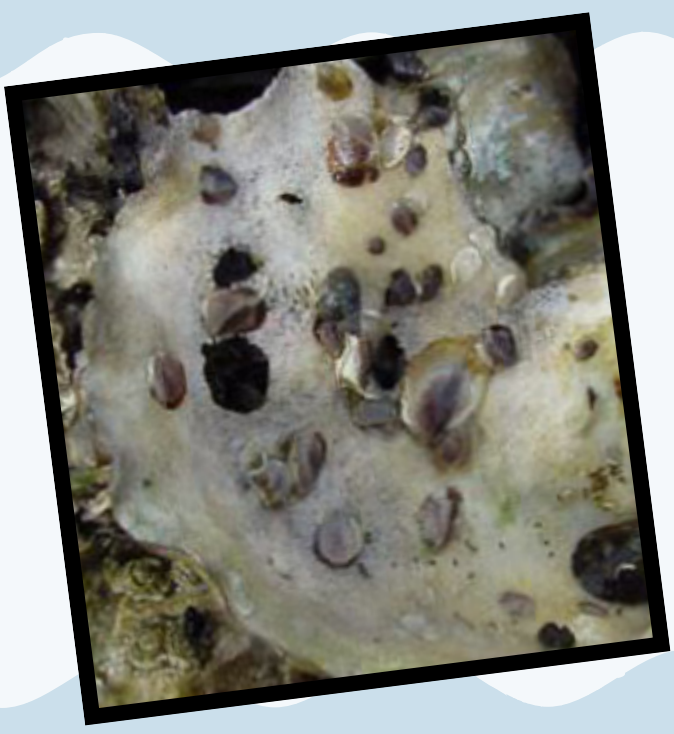
Oysters begin life as tiny eggs in the water. The eggs develop and soon grow into microscopic larvae.

*Not visible to the naked eye.

LARVA

The larva is tiny and free-swimming. It drifts through the water and grows while searching for a good place to settle. It looks for a hard surface, such as an old oyster shell.





SPAT

When the larva settles onto a hard surface, it becomes a spat, which is a young oyster. It attaches to the surface, grows its shell, and begins filtering tiny food particles from the water.

ADULT

The spat continues to grow until it becomes an adult oyster. Adult oysters stay attached to a hard surface and filter food from the water. When they reproduce, they produce new eggs and the life cycle begins again.



References

https://www.chesapeakebay.net/discover/field-guide/entry/eastern-oyster
https://oceanservice.noaa.gov/facts/spat.html
https://marinelab.fsu.edu/absi/community-engagement/aboutoyster/lifecycle_anatomy/